

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS
BOOK 9 OF 12

Where the Stone Was

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For the stone you have carried too long, and for the day you finally set it down.



Father Lucas



BOOK 9

This book: Forgiving others, forgiving yourself, and making peace with God: setting down the stone.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

BOOK 9

The Year of Untied Knots · Days 245 to 275 · Father Lucas

ABOUT THIS MONTH

The arc: First the stone itself, what it weighs and what forgiving is not. Then the people it costs most: the sister, the friend, the church, the one who betrayed you. Then yourself, and the confession you may have been putting off. Last, the debt you release and the candle that takes the stone's place.

Psalm of the month: Psalm 130, "Out of the depths."

"Out of the depths I have cried to you, the LORD. Lord, hear my voice. Let your ears be attentive to the voice of my petitions." — Psalm 130:1-2 (WEB)

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

You have walked eight months of mornings with me, and I think you are braver than you know. This one is the hardest in the book, so I'll say it plainly before we begin.

Everyone carries a stone. A name that stings. A sentence that was never said. A mistake of your own that you have told yourself you can't be forgiven for. I have carried all three.

This month we don't throw the stone. We set it down, slowly, one finger at a time, with Mary's hand under yours. Some days you'll pick it up again. That's all right. Come back.

— Father Lucas

THE MONTH IN FOUR WEEKS

Week 1 (Days 1 to 7): The stone. What forgiving is and isn't, the name you skip, and mercy for the face in the mirror.

Week 2 (Days 8 to 14): The old sin, the confessional, a sister or brother, angry words, a betrayal, and the heavy coat.

Week 3 (Days 15 to 21): A friend, the church that hurt you, a letter you tear up, the dead, and your anger at God.

Week 4 (Days 22 to 31): Parents, saying sorry first, yourself, a debt, your jaw, and the candle where the stone was.

THREE PROMISES FOR THIS MONTH

1. I will set the stone down each morning, even if I lift it again.
2. I will say one name aloud, even the one that stings.
3. I will be as gentle with myself as I am with a friend.

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WEEK 1

The stone

DAYS 245 TO 251

What forgiving is and isn't, the name you skip, and mercy for the face in the mirror.



DAY 245

The Stone in Your Pocket

If you, Yah, kept a record of sins, Lord, who could stand? But there is forgiveness with you, therefore you are feared.

PSALM 130:3-4 (WEB)

You've carried something small and heavy for a long time. You know which one. Your hand finds it before you do, when the phone rings, or when a certain name comes up at the table.

Here's what I've noticed in a lot of kitchens. People say they can't forget the hurt. But it isn't kept in the memory. It's kept in the fist. A memory is easy to live with. A closed hand gets tired.

So this month we won't throw the stone. We'll open the hand, one finger at a time. Today we only find out how heavy it is.

Mother Mary, I have carried this stone so long I forgot it was a stone. Here it is in my hand, with all its edges. I'm not ready to throw it, and I'm not asking to be. Only stay beside me while I look at it. Show me which finger to loosen first, and give me the patience to do it slowly. Amen.



TODAY

Find a small stone or a key. Hold it in your fist for one minute. Then open your palm and set it on the kitchen counter, where you'll see it.

☐ DONE

Whose name makes my hand close, even now?

PSALM

130 — out of the depths; the psalm for a heart that has kept score too long and wants out.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that handed you this stone is still out there. Set it down today, then come back tomorrow and set it down again. That's how a knot stays loose.



DAY 246

Forgive Is Not Forget

Be careful. If your brother sins against you, rebuke him. If he repents, forgive him.

LUKE 17:3 (WEB)

You've been afraid that forgiving means pretending. It doesn't. Jesus himself said to be careful, and even to speak up. Forgiving is not forgetting.

If a stove burns your hand, you can forgive the stove and still wear a mitt. You can remember what happened and stop paying it rent. Mary remembers every wound her Son took, and she is the gentlest woman in heaven.

So keep the memory. It's yours. It only needs its sting taken out, and that's slow work, done a small piece at a time. Today you begin, and slow is fine.

Lord Jesus, you remembered every wound and still forgave. Teach me to do both. I'm not asking to forget what happened. I'm asking you to take the sting out of it, a little each day. Keep me wise at the door and soft in the heart. Let me remember without bleeding. Be patient with a slow student. Amen.



TODAY

On a card, write two lines. Line one: what happened, in plain words. Line two: what you choose to do with it. Tuck the card under your stone.

☐ DONE

What can I remember without letting it hurt me again?

PSALM

143 — teach me the way to walk; the psalm for someone who needs mercy and good sense together.



DAY 247

Seventy Times Seven

Jesus said to him, "I don't tell you until seven times, but, until seventy times seven.

MATTHEW 18:22 (WEB)

Peter thought seven was generous. It's a lot, when a stranger has hurt you. It's a mountain when it's your own flesh and blood.

Jesus isn't doing arithmetic. He doesn't mean keep a tally and stop at four hundred ninety. He means the hand opens again and again, because the hurt comes back again and again.

When I was young and sure of myself, Father Matthias told me something. "Lucas, you will forgive the same man every morning for a month." He was right. Some mornings it's easy. Some mornings it's like lifting a piano. Say it again anyway.

Mary, Undoer of Knots, I have said "I forgive you" and taken it back by supper. Take it from here. Hold the words in your hands until they're strong enough for mine. Let me say them again today, and again tomorrow, and not be ashamed that I need to. I will keep coming back. Please keep opening the door. Amen.



TODAY

Stand in an empty room and say aloud, "I forgive you," and then the name. If the words stick in your throat, say, "I'm starting to." Starting counts.

☐ DONE

Who have I forgiven at breakfast and blamed again by supper?

PSALM

7 — a shield for a heart that is tired of defending itself all day.



DAY 248

The Name You Can't Pray

But I tell you who hear: love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, and pray for those who mistreat you.

LUKE 6:27-28 (WEB)

There is one name you skip. You read down your list of people to pray for, and your eyes jump over it like a puddle. I know. I've skipped a few myself.

You don't have to pray for good things for that name today. You don't have to feel anything at all. Jesus asks something smaller than we think: say the name, and put it in God's hands. Not on your side. Not on theirs. In his.

Mary has heard names that cost far more than that one, and she stayed where she was. So can you, for one breath.

Father, here is a name I have skipped for years. I won't dress it up or make it nicer than it is. I'm not asking to feel kindly. I'm asking you to hold this person tonight, wherever they are. Hold me too, so my hand opens just a little when I say it. That is all I have today. Amen.



TODAY

Write that name on the big line at the bottom of your Names Page. Small letters are fine. Then say it once aloud, and add, "Mary, please keep them."

☐ DONE

What would change if this name were only a person?

PSALM

25 — show me your paths; a psalm for the one who needs the way shown, step by step.



DAY 249

What They Never Said

Whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone; so that your Father, who is in heaven, may also forgive you your transgressions.

MARK 11:25 (WEB)

Some of us are still waiting for a sentence. "I was wrong." Three little words, and we have waited thirty years for them. Maybe they will never come. Maybe the one who owes them is gone, and the waiting has outlived them.

Here is a hard mercy. You can forgive without hearing them. Not because they earned it, and not because it didn't matter. Because you are tired of standing at that door with your hat in your hand.

Put the hat down. Sit. If somebody has to keep waiting for them, let it be God. He has the time.

It's morning again, and I'm still waiting for words that haven't come. Lord, I'm tired of watching that door. If they ever say them, let me be glad. If they never do, let me be free anyway. Take the waiting out of my hands, and give me something kinder to hold in its place. Amen.



TODAY

Write three words for how that missing apology feels. Cross out the heaviest one. Leave the other two on the page, and say them to Mary.

☐ DONE

If the apology never comes, what will I do with today?

PSALM

32 — blessed is the one forgiven; and the lightness belongs to the forgiver too.



DAY 250

Fix a Little, Release a Lot

with all lowliness and humility, with patience, bearing with one another in love, being eager to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.

EPHESIANS 4:2-3 (WEB)

There's a little you can fix and a lot you can only release. The trick is knowing which is which before supper.

Eileen told me she stayed away from Sal's corner store for a year over one rude word. When she finally walked in, he had kept her newspaper folded behind the register the whole time. That one only needed a door opened. The rest, she handed over.

"Bearing with one another in love." Bearing, not controlling. Do the small part honestly and let God hold the rest. Then pick one ordinary place and make peace there first.

Gentle Mother, show me which part is mine. Give me courage for the small thing I can mend, and an open hand for everything I can't. I'm tired of carrying what was never mine to carry. Let me do my part today, honestly, and then leave the rest with you. You're better at it than I am. Amen.



TODAY

Take a scrap of paper and make two columns: "Mine to mend" and "Mine to hand over." Put one thing in each. Do the first one today.

☐ DONE

Which part of this is truly mine to mend?

PSALM

35 — plead my cause; the psalm for letting heaven argue what you're tired of arguing.



DAY 251

Mercy for Yourself

If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us the sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

1 JOHN 1:9 (WEB)

Be honest. You'd never talk to a friend the way you talk to yourself. Who in your house says the cruelest things to you? Not them. You.

God has already read the whole file. He isn't shocked. He's waiting at the table with the door open, wondering why you won't come in. Mercy for others starts to look possible once you've taken some for yourself.

Today you practice on the one person you have never forgiven: the face in the bathroom mirror. Those tired eyes did what they could, for a very long time.

Lord, I have been my own hardest judge. I know every mistake by heart, and I read them back to myself at night. Teach me to hear your voice over mine. Wash what I can't wash, and quiet the voice that says it's never enough. Let me be as gentle with myself this morning as you are. Amen.



TODAY

Look in the mirror and say aloud, "I did what I could with what I knew." Say it twice, slowly. Then wash your hands and let the water finish it.

☐ DONE

What would I say to a friend who did what I did?

PSALM

51 — have mercy on me; the great psalm of a clean heart and a fresh start.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 252 TO 258

The old sin, the confessional, a sister or brother, angry words, a betrayal, and the heavy coat.



DAY 252

The Sin You Still Carry

He will again have compassion on us. He will tread our iniquities under foot. You will cast all their sins into the depths of the sea.

MICAH 7:19 (WEB)

Maybe you confessed it years ago. The priest spoke the words. You said your penance. And still, some nights, the sin walks in and sits at the foot of the bed.

Hear this plainly. Forgiven is forgiven. Not "mostly." Not "until it comes up again." The verse says God casts it into the depths of the sea. I like to add that he does not send a diver after it.

The one who keeps going back to fish it out is you, with a bucket and a flashlight. Today, stop wading in.

Merciful Father, I confessed this long ago, and still I carry it. I believe you forgave it. Help the rest of me believe it too. When the old shame knocks tonight, let me answer, "That's settled." Let your mercy be louder than my memory, and let me sleep on the shore. I'm a slow learner. You know that. Amen.



TODAY

Say aloud, once, "That was forgiven, and I'm setting it down." Then press your palm flat on the counter beside your stone for one slow breath.

☐ DONE

What did I confess once and punish myself for ever since?

PSALM

73 — nevertheless I am continually with you; the psalm for one who almost slipped and was held.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I picked my own old sin up again, a year after confession, and carried it around like a lunch pail. Nobody had asked me to. Open tomorrow's page and set it down once more. That's all I ask.



DAY 253

Go to Confession

Confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The insistent prayer of a righteous person is powerfully effective.

JAMES 5:16 (WEB)

Some things are best set down in a small room, with a priest on the other side of the screen. That isn't a punishment. It's how God chose to say, "You are forgiven," in a voice you can hear with your ears.

I have sat on that side for more years than I can count. I'll tell you what I hear most: a long sigh, and then, "I didn't think I could say it." Most people tell me the hardest part was the drive over. Nobody has ever shocked me. If it has been years, no one will scold you. They'll be glad you came.

Lord Jesus, you gave your priests the words that say, "You are forgiven." I've been afraid of that door. Give me the nerve to knock. Let the one I meet be gentle, and let me be honest. I want this stone off my back, and I know where you keep the strength to lift it. Walk me in. Amen.



TODAY

Call your parish office and ask one question: "When is confession?" Write the time on a card and put it beside your stone. That is all for today.

☐ DONE

What am I afraid the priest will say to me?

PSALM

79 — help us, God of our salvation; the psalm of people asking mercy for what they did.



DAY 254

The Brother Who Hurt You

He kissed all his brothers, and wept on them. After that his brothers talked with him.

GENESIS 45:15 (WEB)

Remember the long road home, from Book 4? This is the other end of it: not the one who left, but the one who hurt you and is still a phone call away.

A wound from a sister or brother goes deeper than a stranger's, because you shared a kitchen long ago. Tom, who lives two doors down, told me he once stood ten feet from his brother at a funeral. Neither of them moved. "My feet forgot how, Father."

Joseph wept on them first. That's today's verse. Somebody has to move first, and it costs less than you fear.

Lord, you gave me this brother, this sister, the same table in our early years. We have the same silence now in our late ones. I don't know who should move first. Help me to be the one. Make my first sentence small, and make the ear on the other end open. Go ahead of me down the road. Amen.



TODAY

Call that one and ask only, "How are you, really?" Then listen. If it goes to voicemail, say your name and that you called to ask.

☐ DONE

What first sentence could I say without starting a fight?

PSALM

61 — from the end of the earth I call; the psalm for a heart that feels far from its own.



DAY 255

Words You Said in Anger

There is one who speaks rashly like the piercing of a sword, but the tongue of the wise heals.

PROVERBS 12:18 (WEB)

You said it in the heat. A sentence with edges on it, thrown across the kitchen, and it landed. You've replayed it a hundred times, usually around the time the house goes quiet.

Here is the plain good news: you can go back for your own words. You can't unsay them, but you can pick them up and hand over something softer in their place. A real sorry has no "but" in it.

It may be late. Words that were fast to leave are slow to heal. Begin anyway, even if your voice shakes.

Jesus, gentle and patient, I said something sharp, and I can't take it back. I'm sorry for the look on that face. Give me the right words, plain and short. Don't let pride talk louder than love. Let my apology be a small door left open, and let it be received kindly. Walk me to the door. Amen.



TODAY

Write two lines to the one you hurt. First line: "I'm sorry for what I said." Second line: nothing, no "but." Seal the envelope, and decide tomorrow.

☐ DONE

Which words of mine am I still hoping nobody remembers?

PSALM

94 — when I said my foot is slipping, your love held me up; for the one who spoke too fast.

256

DAY 256

The Day You Were Betrayed

Yes, my own familiar friend, in whom I trusted, who ate bread with me, has lifted up his heel against me.

PSALM 41:9 (WEB)

You can name the day. The room, the hour, even what you were wearing. Betrayal doesn't fade like other days. It stays in color.

I won't tell you it wasn't that bad. It was that bad. Jesus knew the same kind of day, with bread still in his hand and a friend's footsteps going out the door.

So today you don't have to do anything about it. Not forgive it, not explain it. You only have to sit in the same room with it, beside someone who has been there before. He won't leave.

Lord, you know what it is to be sold by a friend. Sit with me in that day. I'm not ready to say the big words. I only want not to be alone with it. Let your quiet be bigger than my memory, and let me feel your hand on my shoulder for a little while. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair until the clock has moved five minutes. Don't fix the memory and don't fight it. Let it sit across from you, and breathe.

☐ DONE

Who was I before that day, and what did I leave behind?

PSALM

103 — he will not always accuse; the psalm of a God who is slow to anger and quick to sit beside you.



DAY 257

A Grudge Is a Heavy Coat



Let all bitterness, wrath, anger, outcry, and slander be put away from you, with all malice.

EPHESIANS 4:31 (WEB)

A grudge is a heavy coat. You put it on once, in a cold hour, and it kept you warm. Now the room is warm, and you're still wearing it. Your shoulders ache, and you can't remember why you can't take it off.

Mrs. Doyle, who has cleaned our church for twenty years, once told me she wore hers longer than her wedding dress. "Father," she said, "it wasn't even a good coat."

She hung hers up in the end, and she says some mornings she still reaches for it. Today we hang yours on the hook.

Mary, I put this coat on for good reasons. It kept the cold out. But the cold is gone and the weight is not. Help me find the buttons. Help me lift my arms and let it slide. I don't know who I am without it. Show me. I'd like to meet that person. Amen.



TODAY

Put a small object for the grudge into a box: a button, or a scrap with a name. Close the lid and set the box on a high shelf.

☐ DONE

If I took the coat off, what would I feel first?

PSALM

109 — in return for my love they accuse me, but I am in prayer; for when the whole town seems against you.



DAY 258

Pray a Blessing on Them

not rendering evil for evil or insult for insult; but instead blessing, knowing that you were called to this, that you may inherit a blessing.

1 PETER 3:9 (WEB)

Blessing someone who hurt you is not saying they were right. It's a quiet kind of stubbornness, the kind God has. You refuse to let the hurt be the last thing you give them.

Don't make it big. "God, be good to them" is a blessing. "Keep them from harm" is a blessing. Some days you'll say it through your teeth. That counts too. God hears teeth.

And something curious happens. The hand that is blessing cannot hold the stone at the same time. Start with one person and one sentence, said slowly.

Lord, I bless the one who hurt me. I don't feel it yet, so please feel it for me. Give them what they truly need, even if I would not have chosen it. Let your hand be on their house and their table, and on every door they close. Keep my words small and true. Amen.



TODAY

Bless your breakfast aloud, and then add one more line: "And bless the one who hurt me." Say it plainly, then eat.

☐ DONE

What is the smallest blessing I could mean today?

PSALM

130 — my soul waits for the Lord more than watchmen wait for morning; patience for a slow heart.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 259 TO 265

A friend, the church that hurt you, a letter you tear up, the dead, and your anger at God.



DAY 259

Old Friends, Old Wounds

Hatred stirs up strife, but love covers all wrongs.

PROVERBS 10:12 (WEB)

Old friends hurt in old, particular ways. They know where the tender place is, because you showed them. A careless word from a friend of forty years can cost more than a stranger's slap.

And the silence afterward is the strangest part. You each wait for the other. Months turn into years, and nobody counts them aloud. You see the name in the paper, and your heart gives a little skip.

Proverbs says love covers all wrongs. Today, the only thing you need to cover is the first awkward minute.

Lord, you gave me this friend, and the years we had were good ones. I miss the laughing. I don't even remember who stopped first. Soften my pride and soften theirs. Keep me from rehearsing the argument. Remind me that the friendship is older than the wound, and let one small word cross the quiet between our houses. Amen.



TODAY

Leave a voicemail that says only, "I was thinking of you." Don't ask for anything back, and don't explain. Then put the phone down.

☐ DONE

What was the best day we ever had together?

PSALM

143 — hear my prayer, I spread out my hands; for the friend who needs someone to move first.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Somewhere on your Names Page is a person counting on your prayer today. Say that name first, before the coffee. A knot you ignore doesn't wait politely. Open tomorrow's page.



DAY 260

The Church That Hurt You

Jesus said therefore to the twelve, "You don't also want to go away, do you?" Simon Peter answered him, "Lord, to whom would we go? You have the words of eternal life.

JOHN 6:67-68 (WEB)

Some of you were hurt by the very place that was supposed to hold you. A harsh word from the pulpit. A pew you were told wasn't yours. A door that closed when you needed it open. I'm sorry. I mean that as a priest.

Walt, our retired usher, told me, "The pew never hurt me, Father. People did. And I kept the pew."

Peter wasn't comfortable either, and still he said, "Lord, to whom would we go?" Stay near the Lord, even if you must stay away from the room for a while.

Jesus, the people who hurt me wore the same church as the people who helped me. I'm angry, and I'm still here. Give me back the part of you that they hid. Heal what a hard word closed in me. Let me find you in a quiet pew, a kind face, or my own kitchen. Amen.



TODAY

Say aloud the name of one person who was kind to you in church, and thank God for them. Then say, "Lord, I'm still here."

☐ DONE

What did I love about my faith before that day?

PSALM

7 — in you I take refuge; a psalm for the one who was hurt by people who prayed.

261

DAY 261

Father, Forgive

When he was cursed, he didn't curse back. When he suffered, he didn't threaten, but committed himself to him who judges righteously.

1 PETER 2:23 (WEB)

They were dividing his clothes while he said it. Think of that. The nails were still fresh. The soldiers were bargaining over a coat in the dust. He looked at them and said, "Father, forgive them."

He didn't wait for them to ask. He didn't wait for the pain to ease. He forgave in the middle of it. So forgiveness isn't what you do when the pain is over. It's how you get through.

You can pray his words even if you can't mean them yet. He'll mean them for you, until you can.

Father, forgive them. I say his words because I have no better ones. Forgive them for what they knew and what they didn't. Forgive me, too, for what I did while I was holding my own grudge. Turn my stony face toward yours. Let your pardon be bigger than my pride. Say them with me until they're mine. Amen.



TODAY

Say Jesus's words three times, slowly: once for someone who hurt you, once for yourself, once for someone you hurt. Pause between each one.

☐ DONE

Who may be waiting for me to forgive them?

PSALM

25 — do not remember the sins of my youth; the psalm of a God who forgets on purpose.



DAY 262

A Letter You Tear Up

I, even I, am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake; and I will not remember your sins.

ISAIAH 43:25 (WEB)

Write the letter. Say all of it: the dates, the names, the thing they said at the kitchen door. Don't be fair. Don't be polite. The page can take it, and God has already read it over your shoulder.

I keep a shoebox of such letters in my hall closet, every one unsent. I used to think they were proof. Now I think they were how I carried the stone, a page at a time.

Then comes the best part. You tear it up, slowly, into strips. The words were real. The paper doesn't need to keep them.

Lord, here are all the words I never said. They are not pretty, and they are mine. Take them as they are. Take the heat out of them, and take the sting out of me. I don't need them anymore. Keep whatever is true in them. When the paper tears, let something in my chest come loose too. Amen.



TODAY

Write the whole letter, ugly and honest. Read it once. Then tear it into strips, drop them in the wastebasket, and say, "It's yours, Lord."

☐ DONE

Which sentence in that letter was really about me?

PSALM

32 — when I kept silence my bones wasted away; the psalm of the relief that comes when it is finally said.



DAY 263

What Anger Protects

He who is slow to anger has great understanding, but he who has a quick temper displays folly.

PROVERBS 14:29 (WEB)

Anger is rarely the first thing you felt. Under it there is usually something softer that needed a bodyguard. Fear. Shame. Grief. Love that wasn't returned.

Marguerite, from our choir, told me she was furious for a month after her husband fell ill. First at the doctor, then the nurse, then at the sparrows outside her kitchen window. Then she said, "Father, it was guarding my fear."

The verse isn't scolding. It praises the one who is slow to anger, who stops to understand it. Today, with no hurry, we ask the anger what it is guarding.

Mary, I am angry, and I won't pretend otherwise. Thank you for staying in the room when I'm like this. Show me what my anger is guarding. If it's fear, let me name it. If it's grief, let me cry. Teach the guard to stand down, and trust you with the door. Sit with me a while. Amen.



TODAY

Finish this sentence on paper: "My anger is protecting..." Write the first thing that comes, even if it surprises you. Fold the page under your stone.

☐ DONE

What would I have to feel if I stopped being angry?

PSALM

35 — you have seen it, Lord, do not be silent; the psalm that says someone has noticed.



DAY 264

Forgive the Dead



Now he is not the God of the dead, but of the living, for all are alive to him.

LUKE 20:38 (WEB)

The hardest to forgive are the ones who can't answer. A father who never said it. A mother who said too much. A husband who left his bad temper and his bills in the same drawer.

Now it's quiet, and the argument can only go one way. That is what makes it so heavy: there is no one to hear "sorry," no one to say it back.

Jesus says God is the God of the living, for all are alive to him. Your dead are not outside the room where forgiveness is spoken. Say it there. It is heard.

Lord, you hold the ones I have lost, and you hold the things I never settled with them. I forgive what I can. I ask pardon for what I did. Carry my words to them, because you are where they are. Give me peace in the quiet house, and let their rest be deep. Amen.



TODAY

Say aloud to the empty room, "I forgive you, and I ask your pardon too." Say their name first. Then stay quiet for a full minute and listen.

☐ DONE

What do I most wish I had said to them?

PSALM

139 — where could I flee from your presence; even those beyond our sight are not beyond God's reach. (Cambiado desde el 140, que no encaja con el día.)



DAY 265

When You Are Angry at God

How long, LORD? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?

PSALM 13:1 (WEB)

Say it. You're angry at God. For the one he took, or the one he didn't spare, or the years he stayed silent while you begged. You may feel you committed a sin just by thinking it.

You haven't. The psalms are full of people shouting at heaven, and the Bible kept every word. God would rather have your fury than your polite absence. A shouting child is still in the room.

If you can't say it to him, write to Sister Camille. She has heard it before, and she never flinches.

Lord, I'm angry at you. There, I said it. You know what for. I won't pretend I'm fine, because I'm too tired for polite. Stay in the room while I shout, and don't leave when I stop. Hold my fist in your hand until it opens by itself. Stay near me tonight. Be patient with me. Amen.



TODAY

Say aloud, "I'm angry, Lord, and I'm still here." Say it twice, once loud and once soft. Then sit and let the silence answer for a minute.

☐ DONE

What do I want God to know that I have never said?

PSALM

13 — how long, Lord? A psalm that begins in fury and ends in a small, stubborn trust. (Cambiado desde el 51, ya usado el día 7.)



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 266 TO 275

Parents, saying sorry first, yourself, a debt, your jaw, and the candle where the stone was.



DAY 266

Parents Did Their Best

When my father and my mother forsake me, then the LORD will take me up.

PSALM 27:10 (WEB)

Your parents were people. They had their own mothers and fathers, and their own stones. They gave you what they had, and some of it was too little, and some was too much, and some of it was cruel.

None of that makes your hurt small. But there is a quieter truth under it. They were likely doing their best with what they carried, and their best fell short of what you needed.

The verse says even a father and mother can forsake. God takes you up. Whatever they couldn't give, he is still giving.

Father in heaven, you know what I needed and didn't get. I won't deny it. But I'm tired of living in that old house. Let me see my mother and my father as the frightened children they once were. Forgive them, and forgive me for blaming longer than I should. Fill what is empty. Amen.



TODAY

Write one thing from your childhood that went all right, even if it was small: a song, a meal, a pair of hands. Then say thank you for it.

☐ DONE

Which small kindness from them do I tend to forget?

PSALM

73 — nevertheless I am continually with you; the psalm for a grown child who still aches over the house they grew up in.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Forgiveness is not a door you walk through once. A week without prayer, and the old resentments come back in a new coat. Keep these few minutes. The thread stays loose in the hands that keep touching it.



DAY 267

Say Sorry First

leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift.

MATTHEW 5:24 (WEB)

Pride says the other one owes you the first word. Often they do. And a long, stiff silence can sit between two people who each think the other should lift the first stone.

Dale, from Dayton, told me he and his wife Patricia once went a whole week in one kitchen without a word. On the eighth morning he said, "I'm sorry I was loud," and she laughed, a dish towel in her hand. The week had cost more than the argument.

Go first. It's lighter than waiting, and you can sit down sooner.

Lord Jesus, you came down first, before any of us asked. Make me brave enough to go first today. Take the pride out of my chest and put something plainer there. Let my voice be steady. Let the other person hear what I mean, and not only what I sound like. Be with me on the phone. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person you owe a sorry. Say, "I was wrong about one thing," and name it. Then stop. Don't wait to hear theirs.

☐ DONE

What is my pride costing me this week?

PSALM

79 — let your tender mercies meet us; the psalm of someone who needs mercy to move first.

268

DAY 268

Your Own Forgiveness

I have blotted out, as a thick cloud, your transgressions, and, as a cloud, your sins. Return to me, for I have redeemed you.

ISAIAH 44:22 (WEB)

You have forgiven nearly everyone by now. Haven't you noticed? The list is getting short. But there is one name on it that you keep moving to the bottom: your own.

You know exactly what you did. You can tell it with dates. And you tell it every night, like a prosecutor reading charges to an empty room.

God has already blotted it out. The verse says like a cloud, burned away by the morning sun. Don't be more particular than the One you wronged. Let the cloud lift, and let the morning do its work.

Lord, I have forgiven so many. Now the hardest one. I forgive the person who did that thing, who didn't know what I know now. Help me put down the charges. Teach me to take your word over my own record. Let me stand in your mercy like a warm room. Be patient with me. Amen.



TODAY

Put a hand on your heart. Breathe in for four, out for six, three times. On the last breath out, whisper your own name, and then, "forgiven."

☐ DONE

What would I do tomorrow if I believed I was forgiven?

PSALM

94 — in the multitude of my thoughts your comforts delight my soul; for the mind that prosecutes itself.



DAY 269

The Small Slights

The discretion of a man makes him slow to anger. It is his glory to overlook an offense.

PROVERBS 19:11 (WEB)

Big wounds get all the attention. But small slights fill the drawer: the invitation that never came, the grandchild who forgot to call, the neighbor who didn't wave. Each one is a pebble. You don't notice the weight until your pocket is full.

It is a mercy to overlook. Proverbs calls it the glory of a person. It isn't weakness. It's choosing the better room in your heart, and living there.

The easiest hurts to drop are the small ones. Let's practice there, before we try the mountain, and see how it feels.

Gentle Mother, I keep a quiet list of small unkindnesses. I'm too proud to say they bother me, and too tired to keep carrying them. Take the list. Teach me to overlook what doesn't deserve my attention, and to speak kindly when it does. Make my heart roomy, and slow to count. I'm only practicing. Amen.



TODAY

Find one old message that keeps a small hurt alive, and delete it. If you have none, think of one slight and say aloud, "I'm not keeping that."

☐ DONE

Which pebble am I carrying that I could drop today?

PSALM

103 — he knows how we are made and remembers we are dust; a gentle psalm for small injuries.



DAY 270

Peace Offering

Don’t be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.

ROMANS 12:21 (WEB)

The oldest treaties were signed over food. A plate at the door says what the mouth can't yet. It says, "I'm not at war with you," and nobody has to lose the argument.

Walt, our retired usher, once left a coffee cake at the door of a man he had feuded with over a parking space. The plate came back washed, with a note: "Thanks, you old goat." That was the whole treaty. Nobody mentioned the parking space again. They sat together at the next parish picnic.

Overcome evil with good isn't a poster. It's a plate.

Lord, you fed the ones who doubted you, and you ate with the ones who failed you. Let me do something small like that. Take my hands and let them carry something kind to a door I have avoided. I don't need a thank-you. I only need the quarrel to lose its hold on me. Stay with me at the door. Amen.



TODAY

Bake or buy something small, and leave it at the door of someone you have quarreled with. No speech. Sign it with only your first name.

☐ DONE

What would I want to be handed if I were them?

PSALM

109 — they may curse, but you bless; the psalm that lets the last word be God's.

271

DAY 271

Sit Down With the Past

I remember the days of old. I meditate on all your doings. I contemplate the work of your hands.

PSALM 143:5 (WEB)

We spend years running from an old hurt, and it follows, because it isn't fast. It's patient. Today, instead of running, you sit it down at your table.

Carry your coffee to the table. Set the stone beside you. Look at the thing the way you'd look at an old dog that followed you home: tired, a bit mangy, no longer dangerous.

You are not the person who got hurt. You're older now, and Mary is beside you. Speak to the past kindly. Remember what it gave you, too. Then tell it to go home.

Lord, I am sitting down with what I've been running from. It looks smaller in daylight. Be at this table with me. Let me say what is true without trembling. Let me thank the past for what it taught me, and tell it, gently, that it can go. Keep my chair steady, and my voice kind. Amen.



TODAY

Pour your coffee and carry it to the kitchen table with your stone. Say, "Sit. I'm not afraid of you anymore." Then drink slowly.

☐ DONE

What did that time teach me that I would not trade?

PSALM

130 — with the Lord there is abundant redemption; the psalm of a long hope that has come to rest.



DAY 272

Release a Debt

The lord of that servant, being moved with compassion, released him and forgave him the debt.

MATTHEW 18:27 (WEB)

Someone owes you. It may be money, or an apology, or years. You've kept the account in your head: who, what, how long. You know it to the penny.

Jesus tells of a master who, moved with compassion, forgave a servant his whole debt. Then he makes the point that our forgiving and our being forgiven are knotted together, and you can't pull one out without the other.

I'm not telling you what to do about the money. Ask someone you trust. I'm asking you to release the debt in your heart. Let the knot in your chest go slack, even if the account stays open for now.

Our Father, you forgave me a debt I could never pay. Help me loosen my grip on what others owe me. Let me do what is fair, and not one coin more of resentment. Free my mind from the arithmetic, and teach me to be generous without being foolish. Be patient with me. Walk me through it. Amen.



TODAY

Write the name of one person who owes you, and what they owe. Draw a line through it and write "released" beneath. Say the Our Father slowly.

☐ DONE

What would I do with all the room in my head?

PSALM

86 — you are good, and ready to forgive; the psalm of a person who is poor and asks anyway.



DAY 273

Unclench Your Jaw

You will keep whoever's mind is steadfast in perfect peace, because he trusts in you.

ISAIAH 26:3 (WEB)

Do you feel it? Wherever you are sitting, check your jaw. It's clenched. It has probably been clenched since you got up this morning. We carry forgiveness in the body: the jaw, the shoulders, the fist around the coffee cup.

The body keeps a ledger the mind has forgotten. When the stone goes down in the heart, the jaw is often the last to hear the good news.

Perfect peace doesn't mean no troubles. It means a mind held steady on one thing. Your jaw can learn that too. Give it something to trust.

Lord, I thank you for this body, which has carried so much for so long. It holds what my words can't say. Loosen my jaw, and loosen my hands, and let my shoulders come down from around my ears. Let your peace go through me like warm water. Teach me to rest like the child I was. Amen.



TODAY

Drop your shoulders. Loosen your jaw. Open both hands, palms up, in your lap. Stay that way for one slow Hail Mary.

☐ DONE

Where in my body do I still hold the old hurt?

PSALM

143 — I spread out my hands to you; the psalm of the open, empty palm.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A door you've opened can drift shut. Check it each morning, the way you check the stove before you leave the house. Forgiveness left alone swings back toward the old hurt before you notice.



DAY 274

Light Where Resentment Was

Don't rejoice against me, my enemy. When I fall, I will arise. When I sit in darkness, the LORD will be a light to me.

MICAH 7:8 (WEB)

Resentment has a particular darkness. It isn't loud. It's low. It hums in the back of the house like a refrigerator you stopped hearing years ago. You stopped hearing it, but your sleep never did.

A candle is a very small argument against that dark, and a very good one. It doesn't fight the darkness. It simply stays lit.

So light one where your stone has been sitting on the counter. Watch the flame lean, and settle. Where resentment sat, there is now a little light. That's the whole sermon.

Lord, you said you would be a light to me when I sit in darkness. I have sat in this one a long time. Let a small flame stand in the place where my grudge stood. Let it say what I can't: that I am turning toward you. Keep it burning in the quiet of my heart. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle beside your stone. Count ten slow breaths while you watch the flame. Pray nothing. Just watch. Blow it out with an "Amen."

☐ DONE

What is lighter in me than it was a month ago?

PSALM

7 — I will give thanks to the LORD; the psalm that ends in thanks, after a long trial.



DAY 275

The Candle Where the Stone Was

I will give them one heart, and I will put a new spirit within them. I will take the stony heart out of their flesh, and will give them a heart of flesh,

EZEKIEL 11:19 (WEB)

Look at your counter. For a month a small stone has sat there, and you've walked around it with your coffee. You told it things. Some mornings you picked it up. Some mornings you wanted to throw it.

Now take the stone away, and put a candle where it was. That spot is no longer the spot of the grudge. It is the spot of the work you did. The hurt happened. So did this.

You didn't forget. You set it down. That is the whole victory, and it is enough.

Mother Mary, Undoer of Knots, here is the place where the stone sat, and here is a flame in its place. Thank you for every morning I came back, even the ones when I came with my hands closed. Keep what is loosened loose. When a knot tries to tie again, find me, and help me begin. Amen.



TODAY

Light your candle where the stone was. Say aloud one name from your Names Page, and then, "Mary, please keep them." Blow it out with an "Amen."

☐ DONE

Which morning this month was hardest, and who was beside me?

PSALM

25 — for your name's sake, pardon my iniquity; the psalm that opened this month, closing it.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The stone you set down today is not the stone you will meet tomorrow. Hurts grow back like weeds in a path, and forgiveness is daily bread. Come back, set it down again, and keep the candle.

LOOKING BACK · BOOK 9

Take your pen. Answer in a line each, and tick the box when you have.

[ ] Which name did I finally say aloud this month?

[ ] What did I set down that I thought I would carry forever?

[ ] Whom did I call, write to, or leave a plate for?

[ ] Where does the stone try to come back, and what will I do then?

A LETTER AT THE CLOSE OF THE MONTH

My friend,

Look at your counter. There is a candle where a stone used to be. Remember how heavy that stone felt on the first morning, and how it feels to look at the empty place now.

I won't tell you it's gone for good. Stones have a way of finding pockets. Some morning soon, a phone will ring, or a name will come up at supper, and your hand will close. When it does, don't be ashamed. Open it again. That is the whole practice, and it's all I know.

You have forgiven more this month than you thought you could, and I hope that includes yourself. Mary saw every morning of it. So did I.

— Father Lucas

THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS · BOOK 9 · SET DOWN THE STONE

Date:

THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH: WHERE THE STONE WAS

1. Light a candle in the place on your counter where the stone sat.

2. Read three names from your Names Page aloud, and after each one say, "Mary, please keep them."

3. Blow out the flame with an "Amen."



THIS CERTIFIES THAT

NAME

Nine Months, Nine Knots

Two hundred seventy-five mornings.
You set down the stone, and kept going.

Father Lucas

DATE

AUGSBURG

NOTES

What changed this month:

Names to add:

Turn to Book 10 tomorrow.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 9 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 10 · THE WINDOW